UNIT 1: BEGINNING YOUR JOURNEY, CAREER READINESS ORIENTATION

TOPIC 4: HOW BELIEFS/ATTITUDE AFFECT DECISIONS

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the impact of attitude, self-talk, and perception on her/his life
- Understand that personal beliefs can impact personal success or failure
- Understand better how they make decisions and learn about different ways to make decisions

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Identify what is in their circle of control and what is outside of their circle of control
- Create positive self-talk statements (affirmations)
- Reflect on how they make decisions

Topic ACTIVITIES:

I. Welcome to the Day

Opening Question:

- If you could change one thing in the world what would it be?
- If you could give up one bad habit, what would it be?
- If you could have any superpower, which power would you want? Why?

Opening Quote:

- "Change your thoughts and you change your world."
  ~ *Norman Vincent Peale* (Protestant preacher and author)
- "You can tell more about a person by what he says about others than you can by what others say about him."
  ~ *Anonymous*
- "The pessimist sees difficulty in every opportunity. The optimist sees the opportunity in every difficulty."
  ~ *Winston Churchill* (British Prime Minister)
- "The truth is that it's what we say to ourselves in response to any particular situation that mainly determines our mood and feelings."
  ~ *Edward J. Bourne* (author)
- "The inner speech, your thoughts, can cause you to be rich or poor, loved or unloved, happy or unhappy, attractive or unattractive, powerful or weak."
  ~ *Ralph Charell* (author)
- "The way life treats you is a merciless mirror image of your attitude toward life."
  ~ *Anonymous*
- "Things are not happening to you. Things are happening because of you."
  ~ *Anonymous*
- "A man is what he thinks all day long."
  ~ *Ralph Waldo Emerson* (essayist, philosopher and poet)
- "If you change the way you look at things, the things you look at change"
  ~ *Dr. Wayne Dyer* (self-help author and speaker)

Real-World Application Check-in:

- Ask participants to share observations and thoughts.

II. Activities

1. Mindchatter

Context: The inner "voice" chattering in our minds strongly affects our behavior in a situation. It can be a powerful tool for centering, or a powerful distraction.

Time: 5 minutes

Aim: To recognize and acknowledge mindchatter. To practice controlling mindchatter, using it to clear and relax participants' minds at the start of a session.

Materials: Pens, paper

Instructions: When we start a new activity, we are often distracted by something on our mind. It may be something that happened today, something imminent, something we must remember to do, or other important personal matters. Our minds tend to chatter about this and distract us.

This activity controls this "mindchatter" and focuses our attention.

Take about 3 minutes to write down any mindchatter you are experiencing at present. If it includes anything you must do, write it at the top of the page. If it is "nuisance" chatter, write it at the bottom of the page.

When it is complete, tear the top ("must do") from the bottom ("nuisance"). Put away the "must do" list in your bag safely, and place the "nuisance" section in your folder.

Now you should have a clearer, more relaxed mind to start the session.

© The Conflict Resolution Network PO Box 1016 Chatswood NSW 2057 Australia Ph. 61 2 9419 8500 Fax 61 2 9413 1148 E-mail: crn@crnhq.org Web: **www.crnhq.org** *Icebreakers and Energizers A.II.6*

2. Focus

Supplies: No supplies needed

Directions:

- Tell participants they have 30 seconds to study and remember all of the (color) things in the room. (Choose a color that has many obvious items).
- At the end of the 30 seconds, ask participants to close their eyes.
- With their eyes closed, have them list all of the (different color) things in the room. (At this point people will usually open their eyes or tell you that you said the wrong color or just start listing the things they focused on for the 30 seconds).
- Discussion Questions:
  - Why would I tell you to study and remember things of one color and then ask you to name things of a different color?
  - How many of you did not even notice the (second color) things in the room?
  - How often do we only see what we focus on?
  - How often do we focus on negative things — and only see negative things?
  - How often do other people focus on negative things about us — and only see the negative?
  - What happens when we focus on positive things?
  - Today we are going to discuss how our beliefs and what we focus on impacts our decisions and our lives.
- Return to Mindchatter lists
  - How many thoughts were positive?
  - How many thoughts were negative?

3. How Many Squares?

Supplies: large drawing of diagram included, copies of diagram or projection of diagram

Directions:

- Ask participants how many squares are in the picture.
- Have them all write down their answers, collect their answers and read them out loud.
- Challenge everyone to keep looking until they find all of the squares (There are 30).
- Make sure everyone sees all 30 squares before discussing the activity.

Discussion Questions:

- How many of you thought you were right with your first answer? Second answer? How long did it take to actually find all of the squares?
- What did you learn from this activity? OR What could someone learn from this activity?
- How can you apply what you learned to other areas of your life? To work?
- How often in life do we think we are right even though we might miss some of the details or the big picture?
- What does it take to convince you that what you think is right might not actually be right?
- (Question to think about — not necessarily answer out loud) Are there things you believe about yourself that might not be true? (things you think you can't do, things you think you lack, things you can't learn).

III. Own Your Attitude

(Adapted from: http://ctetriocurriculum.v2efolioworld.mnscu.edu/Uploads/Owning%20Your%20Attitude%20Lesson%20Plan.doc)

1. Large Group Discussion Questions

- What is attitude? The way you mentally look at the world around you and how you react to it.
- What is Optimism? Expecting the best.
- What is Pessimism? Expecting the worst.

2. Small Group Activity

In small groups, answer the following questions on flip chart:

- What does a bad (negative) attitude look like?
- What does a good (positive) attitude look like?

Have the small groups present their answers, and discuss positive and negative attitudes with the large group. Make sure to discuss why it is important to have a positive attitude at work.

3. Large Group Discussion: Learn to respond not react, the difference between being reactive and proactive

- Reactive people feel that circumstances are out of their control and that their reactions are dictated by something or someone other than themselves.

  Examples: "My girlfriend makes me so mad!"
  "That teacher sucks! I'll never learn anything!"
  "You ruined my day"

  Reactive people make choices based on impulse. They are like a can of soda — if life shakes them up a bit, the pressure builds until they suddenly explode.

  Reactive Response:
  Stimulus (What happens) ➔ Response (How I respond based on the emotion of the moment)

- Proactive people think before they act. They choose their responses and take responsibility (and control) over their feelings and reactions to challenges.

  Examples: "I'm not going to let that ruin my day."
  "Is there a different strategy I can use to learn this stuff?"

  Proactive people are like water — no fizzing, no bubbling, no pressure; they are calm, cool, and in control.

  Proactive Response:
  Stimulus (What happens) ➔ Freedom to Choose ➔ Response (How I respond based on my values and principles)

4. Scenarios:

Ask students to listen to the following scenarios and share different reactions to the situation. Write the reactions on the board/flipchart.

Together, decide if the reaction is Proactive or Reactive. Make sure you have a decent list of proactive and reactive responses.

- Your boyfriend/girlfriend shows up at your job and starts yelling at you for not replying to her/his text messages.
- You've been working at your job for over a year now and have been extremely committed and dependable. Three months ago, a new employee joined the crew. Recently, he was given the coveted Saturday afternoon shift, the shift you were hoping for.
- You are on your way out on a Friday night when your mom asks you where you are going. She tells you that she has plans and needs you to baby-sit your little brother and sister tonight.

5. Activity: Circle of Control

- For sure, it's easy to lose your cool. That doesn't take any control. And it's easy to whine and complain. Without question, being proactive is the higher, harder road. But remember, you don't have to be perfect. In reality, we aren't either completely proactive or reactive, but somewhere in between. The key is to get in the habit of being proactive more often.
- The fact is that we can't control everything that happens to us. We can't control the color of our skin, who will win the NBA finals, where we were born, who our parents are, or how others might treat us. But there is one thing we can control: how we respond to what happens to us. And that is what counts! That is why we need to stop worrying about things we cannot control and start worrying about the things we can control.
- What will happen if we spend our time and energy worrying about things we can't control, like a rude comment, a past mistake or the weather? We'll feel even more out of control, as if we were victims.
- Think about some of the things in your life that you have NO CONTROL of and write them in the Circle of No Control. Think about what you CAN control and write those things in the Circle of Control (Choices, Responses, Actions, Attitudes).

IV. Self-talk

a. "As a Man Thinketh" Excerpts (included)

Discussion questions:

i. What do you think of these statements?
ii. Which ones do you agree with? Why?
iii. Which ones do you disagree with? Why?

b. Large group discussion:

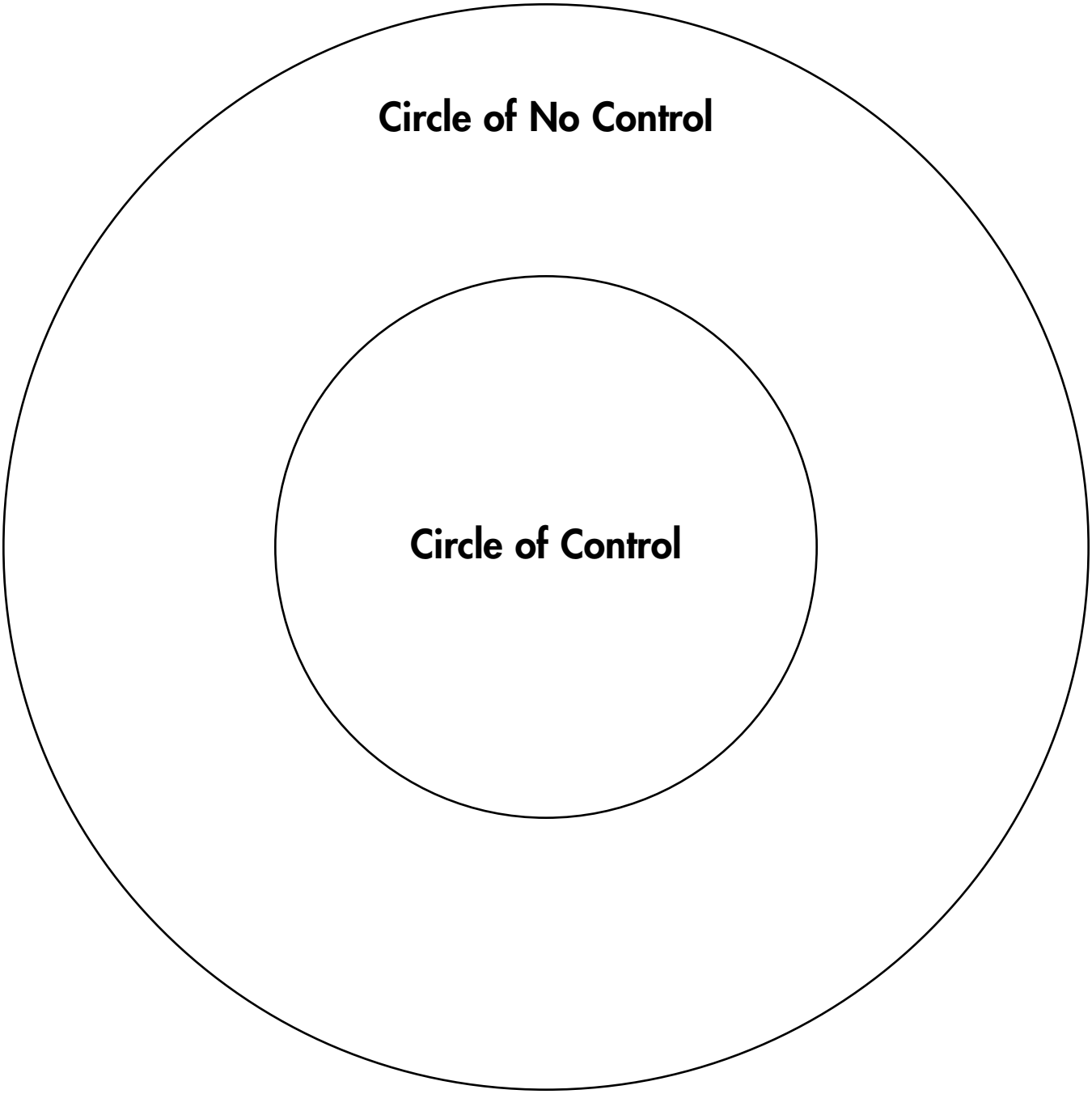
- What are the things we say to ourselves? Are they positive/negative?
- What was going on in your head during today's activities? Yesterday's activities?
- Challenge yourselves to be aware of your negative self-talk. Replace this negative self-talk with affirmations.
- Create affirmations — positive self-talk statements
  - Have each participant create at least five statements that she/he would repeat regularly and use to replace negative self-talk.
  - Examples:
    - I am in charge of my life.
    - I can do anything I believe I can do.
    - I can choose how I respond.

V. Decisions Hand Out

VI. Take out your box from yesterday — is there anything you want to add after today's session? Take a few minutes to add new things to your box.

Real-World Application: Be aware of your self-talk. When is it positive? When is it negative? Were you able to identify the negative self-talk and replace it with an affirmation?

How Many Squares?


Circle of No Control
Circle of Control

"As a Man Thinketh"

Men are anxious to improve their circumstances, but are unwilling to improve themselves; they therefore remain bound.

Good thoughts and actions can never produce bad results; bad thoughts and actions can never produce good results.

Let a man radically alter his thoughts, and he will be astonished at the rapid transformation it will effect in the material conditions of his life. Men imagine that thought can be kept secret, but it cannot. It rapidly crystallizes into habit, and habit solidifies into circumstances.

A man cannot directly choose his circumstances, but he can choose his thoughts, and so indirectly, yet surely, shape his circumstances.

All that a man achieves and all that he fails to achieve is the direct result of his own thoughts... A man's weakness and strength, purity and impurity, are his own, and not another man's. They are brought about by himself and not by another; and they can only be altered by himself, never by another. His condition is also his own, and not another man's. His sufferings and his happiness are evolved from within. As he thinks, so he is; as he continues to think, so he remains.

~ *James Allen*
http://www.asamanthinketh.net/

Decisions

Put a check by the ways you've used to make decisions.

____ **Fate:** It'll work out somehow.

____ **Someone Else Decides:** I'll let someone else make this decision.

____ **Putting It Off:** I'll think about this later.

____ **Impulsive:** I'll take the first alternative that comes up.

____ **Doing Nothing:** I will ignore this completely.

____ **Intuitive:** I will do what feels right.

____ **Too Much Information:** I have so much information I can't decide.

____ **Sensible:** I will take the most sensible solution and ignore my feelings.

____ **Head, heart, gut:** I'll stop and think, weigh my emotions, listen to my intuition.

Think about it:

1. Circle the one(s) you think you use most often.
2. In which ways to make a decision does the person give up his freedom to decide himself?

_____

_____

For each question below, give at least 3 reasons for your opinion. Use a list or a web.

Answer these questions on the back of this paper.

1. What ways would you want your children to use to make decisions?
2. What ways would you want your boss to use to make business decisions?
3. What ways would you want the U.S. government to use to make decisions?

Decisions

Not all decisions need as much thought as others. Some are automatic while others require serious thought.

Use this scale to rate the following decisions. Write the number on the line. Compare and contrast your answers with other group members.

0	1	2	3
Not clearly under your control Someone else decides	Routine Habit Becomes automatic	Think about it a little Study it some	Stop, Think Carefully research Ask questions

____ A. When to get up in the morning?

____ B. What to eat for lunch?

____ C. Where to work?

____ D. What car to buy?

____ E. How to spend your paycheck?

____ F. What career to pursue?

____ G. How to stay healthy?

____ H. Whom to date?

____ I. When to swear?

____ J. Who to trust as a loyal friend?

____ K. What route to take from home to work?

Think about it:

Write your answers on the back of this paper.

1. Were there major differences in the way people in your group decide? Write at least three reasons why you think this is the case.
2. Situations and people change all the time. What changes could cause your answers to change? List or web at least 3.

Did I Ever Tell You

~ *Dr. Seuss*

Did I ever tell you about the young Zode
Who came to two signs at the fork of a road?
One said: To Place One, and the other: Place Two.
So the Zode had to make up his mind what to do.
Well... the Zode scratched his head. And his chin. And his pants
And he said to himself, "I'll be taking a chance
If I go to Place One. Now, that place may be hot!
And, so how do I know if I'll like it or not
On the other hand, though, I'll be sort of a fool
If I go to Place Two and I find it too cool.
In that case I may catch a chill and turn blue!
So, maybe, Place One is the best, not Place Two.
On the other hand, though, If Place One is too high.
I may catch a terrible earache and die!
So Place Two may be best!
On the other hand, though...
What might happen to me if Place Two is too low...?
I might get some very strange pain in my toe!
Then he stopped, and he said, "On the OTHER hand, though...
On the other hand... other hand
... other hand though!
And for 36 hours and 1/2, that poor Zode
Made starts and stops at that fork in the road.
Saying, "Don't take a chance. You may not be right."
Then he got an idea that was wonderfully bright!
"Play safe!" cried the Zode. "I'll play safe! I'm no dunce!
I'll simply start off for both places at once!"

And that's how the Zode, who would not take a chance,
Got to No place at All, with a split in his pants.

Decision-making is not an easy process.

When have you felt like the Zode?

Do you have to stick with a decision if you discover problems?

What about always switching back and forth?